forces since May 22, when intelligence was received about their presence in Dachigam. The Intelligence Bureau and the army, he said, used specialised equipment like heat signature drones and satellite imagery to intercept frequencies of the terrorists' communication equipment and pursued them relentlessly for over two months. As per officials involved in the operation, from May 22 to July 22, intelligence agencies along with the CRPF, army and J&K police continuously patrolled the dense and mountainous forest area. And, once confirmed by an intercepted communication, they launched the final combing operation on July 22 after the terrorists were cornered. "Operation Sindoor had killed the bosses of the terrorists... Operation Mahadev killed the terrorists themselves," Shah said. Extensive forensic analysis of the M9 and two AK-47s used by the terrorists, and the matching of ammunition shells generated by firing them at the Chandigarh Central Forensic Science Laboratory with the spent cartridges picked up in Pahalgam, generated a 100 per cent match.

Overall, the government emphasised the success of Op. Sindoor, with defence minister Rajnath Singh praising the military's precision in targeting Pakistani terror hubs. Shah's statement effectively countered the charge about a lax security atmosphere, but the question on how they breached the heavily guarded Line of Control remains unanswered. 'Intelligence lapses' was going to be the key weapon for the star Opposition speakers like Rahul Gandhi, Gaurav Gogoi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra of the Congress, Akhilesh Yadav (Samajwadi Party), Supriya Sule (NCP-SP) and Kalyan Banerjee (TMC).

However, security forces are looking to plug the gaps. "We need a smart counter-infiltration grid combining tech with boots on the ground," says a top army officer serving in Kashmir. The army must invest in synthesising signals intelligence, human intelligence and surveillance technologies, he feels. "The counter-terrorism grid should be reviewed, with CAPF (Central Armed Police Forces) and police in the inner tier and army/Rashtriya Rifles in the outer tier, ensuring army dominance in higher reaches and outer areas," a former corps commander suggests. Another officer says the military should have contingency plans vis-a-vis the scale of terror attacks and the enemy shouldn't get the time to be prepared, as they did after Pahalgam.

Leaders like Akhilesh and Rahul questioned the reason for a ceasefire when India had the upper hand. "When our army had brought Pakistan to its knees, why did we agree to a ceasefire?" asked the former, tipping then to the rhetorical troughs previously owned by the BJP: "It was the best time to advance towards PoK." Rahul asked pointed questions about the veracity of US President Donald Trump's repeated claims of brokering peace. In words not so felicitously chosen at a time of trade negotiations, he demanded that the appellation "liar" be used if he was wrong. PM Modi emphasised that no world leader had asked India to stop Op. Sindoor, and that India agreed to a ceasefire after it met all its objectives and Pakistan begged for it.

A key government official admits to a more layered story. "It's clear there was an off-ramp and third-party intervention," he says. "Trump's character fits his claim of taking credit for preventing a nuclear war, which oversimplifies nuanced diplomacy.... Acknowledging this intervention might be politically challenging for India."



ANI

JOB WELL DONE Army personnel in Dachigam, near Srinagar, following Operation Mahadev, Jul. 28

POINTS TO PONDER

Unanswered queries raised by the Opposition

- **Possible intelligence failure that enabled Pahalgam terrorists to breach the LoC**
- **Clarity on claims of aircraft lost during the first day of Op. Sindoor**
- **Acknowledgment of China's real-time aid to Pakistan during Op. Sindoor**
- **The diplomatic embarrassment for India as President Trump hosted, and praised, Pakistan army chief Asim Munir**

'ONLY A PAUSE'

Rajnath Singh sought to allay any doubt by reverting to a combative stance, saying Op. Sindoor has only been halted, and that India is prepared for action if Pakistan sponsors another terror act. But the government evaded questions on the Pakistan-China nexus and the loss of Indian jets. Military observers claim Chinese satellites gave live battlefield inputs to Pakistan, something deputy chief of army staff Lt. Gen Rahul R. Singh alluded to at a FICCI event on July 4. Chief of Defence Staff Gen. Anil Chauhan, in a May 31 interview, too, had admitted to the loss of jets due to "a tactical mistake".

On India's diplomatic blitz, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar said all 193 UN member countries, barring three, stood with India. However, he did not address another matter raised by Rahul—that of Trump inviting Pakistani army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir to the White House on July 18 and praising him for de-escalating the conflict.

Though the government has sidestepped a few queries, it has provided clarity on crucial elements. Most importantly, justice has been served to the perpetrators of Pahalgam. ■